



Invoice

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An invoice is a time-stamped commercial document that itemizes and records a transaction between a buyer and a seller. If goods or services were purchased on credit, the invoice usually specifies the terms of the deal and provides information on the available methods of payment.

Types of invoices may include a paper [receipt](#), a bill of sale, [debit note](#), sales invoice, or online electronic record.

An invoice must state it is an invoice on the face of the bill. It typically has a unique identifier called the invoice number that is useful for internal and external reference. An invoice typically contains contact information for the seller or service provider in case there is an error relating to the billing.

Payment terms may be outlined on the invoice, as well as the information relating to any discounts, early payment details or finance charges assessed for late payments. It also presents the unit cost of an item, total units purchased, freight, handling, shipping, and associated tax charges, and it outlines the total amount owed.¹

Companies may opt to simply send a month-end statement as the invoice for all outstanding transactions. If this is the case, the statement must indicate that no subsequent invoices will be sent.² Historically, invoices have been recorded on paper, often with multiple copies generated so that the buyer and seller each have a record of the transaction for their own records. Currently, computer-generated invoices are quite common. They can be printed to paper on demand or sent by email to the parties of a transaction. Electronic records also allow for easier searching and sorting of particular transactions or specific dates.

A [pro forma invoice](#) is a preliminary [bill of sale](#) sent to buyers in advance of a shipment or delivery of goods. The invoice will typically describe the purchased items and other important information such as the shipping weight and transport charges. [Pro forma](#) invoices often come into play with international transactions, especially for customs purposes on imports.

The invoice date represents the time-stamped time and date on which the goods have been billed and the transaction officially recorded. Therefore, the invoice date has essential information regarding payment, as it dictates the credit duration and due date of the bill. This is especially crucial for entities offering credit, such as net 30. The actual due date of the invoice is usually 30 days after the invoice date. Likewise, companies offer customers the option to return items typically have a deadline based on a certain number of days since proof of purchase, as indicated on the invoice.

Since the advent of the [computer era](#), people and businesses have found it easier to rely on [electronic invoicing](#) as an alternative to paper documents. Electronic invoicing, or e-invoicing, is a form of electronic billing to generate, store and monitor transaction-related documents between parties and ensure the terms of their agreements are fulfilled.

These e-documents may include invoices and receipts, purchase orders, debit and credit notes, payment terms and instructions, and remittance slips.⁵ Digital invoices are normally sent via email, web page or app. Advantages include the following: